BACLOFEN

Do not stop suddenly

Renal dose adjustment

CHEMICAL NAME (RS)-4-amino-3-(4-chlorophenyl)butanoic acid
CLASS Centrally acting muscle relaxant (GABA-B receptor agonist)
TRADE NAMES Lioresal · Baclosal · Gablofen (intrathecal)

THERAPEUTIC USES / INDICATIONS

- Spasticity from multiple sclerosis, spinal cord injury, cerebral palsy.
- Severe spasticity via intrathecal pump.
- Hiccups and alcohol dependence (off-label).

ADMINISTRATION

- **PO** with food or milk to reduce GI upset.
- **Intrathecal** infusion via implanted pump (specialist).
- Increase slowly; withdraw slowly over 1–2 weeks.

DOSAGES

- **Adult PO:** start 5 mg three times daily; increase by 5 mg per dose every 3 days.
- Usual 60 mg/day; max 100 mg/day.
- **Children:** 0.3 mg/kg/day in divided doses, titrated.
- Renal impairment: reduce dose (e.g. 5 mg daily).

PHARMACOKINETICS

- **Onset:** hours to days; full effect may take weeks.
- Well absorbed; minimal liver metabolism.
- Excreted mainly unchanged in urine (accumulates in renal failure). **t½:** 3–4 h.

PHARMACODYNAMICS

- Agonist at **GABA-B** receptors in spinal cord → inhibits mono- and polysynaptic reflexes.
- Reduces muscle tone, spasms and clonus.

SIDE & ADVERSE EFFECTS

SIDE EFFECTS (COMMON)

- Drowsiness, dizziness, fatigue.
- Muscle weakness, hypotonia.
- Nausea, confusion.

ADVERSE EFFECTS (SERIOUS)

- Encephalopathy and coma in renal impairment.
- Respiratory depression in overdose.
- Withdrawal: hallucinations, seizures, high fever, rebound spasticity (life-threatening with intrathecal pump failure).
- Lowered seizure threshold.

CONTRAINDICATIONS & CAUTIONS

- Hypersensitivity.
- Active peptic ulcer (caution).
- **Caution:** epilepsy, psychiatric illness, renal impairment, stroke, elderly.

KEY INTERACTIONS

- **Alcohol, opioids, sedatives:** ↑ CNS depression.
- **Antihypertensives:** ↑ hypotension.
- **Levodopa:** confusion, hallucinations.

NURSING MANAGEMENT

- Assess spasticity, mobility and muscle strength regularly.
- Monitor renal function, sedation and BP.
- Never stop abruptly; ensure supplies are continuous.
- Intrathecal pump: check refill date; watch for withdrawal signs.
- Fall precautions.

PATIENT EDUCATION

- Do not stop suddenly; risk of fits and hallucinations.
- May cause drowsiness; avoid alcohol and driving.
- Benefit may take several weeks.
- Some muscle tone helps standing — report excessive weakness.

KEY POINTS

- GABA-B agonist for spasticity.
- Abrupt withdrawal is dangerous.
- Renally cleared; reduce dose in kidney disease.
- Max 100 mg/day orally.